THE NOBULOUS SET · CAMPAIGN SUPPLEMENT

Nobulous Research Journal (NRJ)

Three games. One terrible idea.

The Journal reveals that Build-a-Tyrant (BAT), the Nobulous Apprenticeship Program (NAP) and the Automaton of Shale (AoS) were never separate jobs. NAP supplied the knowledge and the brain, BAT supplied the body, AoS supplied the kidnapping and the cover-up. What remains is to walk the finished Imposter into the Council chamber and survive nine rounds of scrutiny.

COMPONENTS

- 18 NRJ cards for BAT — 6 Experimental Protocols, 6 Unauthorized Modifications, 6 Research Notes
- 14 NRJ cards for NAP — 4 Following Setbacks, 4 Impostor Tasks, 6 Devious Opportunities
- 18 NRJ cards for AoS — 6 Nobulous Interference, 6 Corrupted Limitations, 6 Backdoor Routines
- 24 Council Test Scenario cards
- **From 20 Strong:** the 17 unit dice, the 3 stat dice (Health, Strategy, Recovery) and the Chip
- Plus the components of whichever games you are playing

WHAT NRJ ADDS

NRJ has two independent uses. You may use either, or both.

- **Overlay modules.** Optional cards that interfere with each standalone game. Three tiers per game.
- **The campaign.** Play all three games, carry your results forward, and finish with the Imposter Scenario.

> **THE TIERS ARE NOT DIFFICULTY LEVELS**
>
> **Tier I — Agenda** introduces Nobulous' interference. **Tier II — Contamination** injects corrupted material into the game's own decks and is the pressure peak. **Tier III — Exploitation** gives you tools to exploit the mess. Each tier includes the ones before it.

BUILD-A-TYRANT (BAT) MODULE — 18 CARDS

TIER	ADD
I	Draw 1 of the 6 **Experimental Protocols** at setup.
II	Remove 6 ordinary Upgrades from the Upgrade deck and shuffle the 6 **Unauthorized Modifications** in to replace them. Either a Rat or the Tyrant may hold them.
III	Lay the 6 **Research Notes** face-up beside the table. Each prints its own claim condition; take a Note when you meet it, then spend it later for the one-shot reward printed on it. A Note can be claimed only once, and only one copy of each condition exists.

NOBULOUS APPRENTICESHIP PROGRAM (NAP) MODULE — 14 CARDS

TIER	ADD
I	Set the 6 base Setbacks aside and shuffle in **3 of the 4 Following Setbacks**, chosen at random, exactly where the 3 base Setbacks would have gone. Never use both kinds together. An unresolved Following Setback moves into the next Time Slot, including Evening to the next Morning. A Following Setback does **not** lock the row: the restriction printed on the card replaces "no other Assignment may be worked until this Setback is resolved".
II	Add the 4 **Impostor Tasks**, one per subject. Each replaces a Credit Task of the same subject.
III	Replace the 6 Opportunities with the 6 **Devious Opportunities**.

> **IMPOSTOR TASKS**
>
> Impostor Tasks are **Mandatory** and **grant no Credits**. You still have to clear them; clearing them advances nothing.

DEVIOUS OPPORTUNITIES BANK THEIR HELP

Four of the six pay nothing when you complete them: you **keep the card and spend it once during the Final Exam** — or **discard it during the apprenticeship to ignore one Setback's restrictions for the rest of the game**. That Setback stays in its Time Slot and still has to be resolved; it simply stops charging upkeep and stops restricting what else you may work. The other two — *Borrow the Master's Notes* and *Extra Credit?* — resolve immediately, because an exam has no room for them. Tier III replaces the base Opportunities, so NAP's own coupons are not in the deck at this tier: your Opportunity rewards are **banked for the exams** instead of spent along the way. Spending one is free and costs no dice.

AUTOMATON OF SHALE (AOS) MODULE — 18 CARDS

TIER	ADD
I	Draw 1 of the 6 **Nobulous Interference** cards at setup.
II	Shuffle the 6 **Corrupted Limitations** into the Limitation deck.
III	Lay the 6 **Backdoor Routines** face-up beside the table. Each prints a claim condition and a later one-shot use. **You may claim at most 2 per game** — once you have claimed 2 you cannot claim more, even if you meet the other conditions.

Corrupted Limitations are revealed before required-color dice are committed, exactly like native Limitations, and withhold 2 dice of a *randomly selected* color on top of their printed corruption.

PLAYING THE CAMPAIGN

1. **Play at Tier III.** The campaign is Tier III only, because the Research Pool is built out of the Tier III cards themselves — see below. Tiers I and II are for playing the three games on their own.
2. Win BAT, NAP and AoS in any order. **If you lose a game, replay that game only** — the campaign does not restart.
3. Each won game contributes its 6 Tier III cards to the **Research Pool**.
4. Play the Imposter Scenario.

No written bookkeeping is needed. Physical cards and their printed states carry the whole campaign history, and nothing is taken out of the BAT, NAP or AoS decks — every card the finale uses came from this box.

The Research Pool — the Tier III cards you claimed

The Council's evidence against you is the Nobulous material you touched. Each game lays 6 Tier III cards on the table and every one of them is a favour: claim it and that game gets easier. The finale is where the favour is counted.

GAME	TIER III CARDS	ANSWERS	CLAIMED BY
BAT	6 Research Notes	Physical	meeting the printed condition and giving up the next Upgrade a completed Experiment earns
NAP	6 Devious Opportunities	Knowledge	working it like an Assignment, in place of a Credit Task
AoS	6 Backdoor Routines	Cover-Up	meeting the printed condition and giving up the next Program Reward

Retain at most 3 cards per game. If you claimed more, choose which 3 you carry; AoS's own limit of 2 claims a game binds first. What a retained card is worth depends on whether you cashed it in:

HOW THE GAME ENDED WITH IT	IN THE FINALE
Claimed, and never spent	**Retained** — reduces one Exhibit's Target by **2**
Claimed and spent	**Retained** — reduces by **1**
Never claimed	**Candidate** — answers nothing

Keep all 18 face-up and available. A card spent for an effect in the finale is gone for the rest of it.

TIER III IS A LOAN AND THE FINALE IS THE RECKONING

Every one of these cards exists to make its own game easier, so the campaign asks the opposite of each game: finish all three having claimed what you could and *spent* as little of it as you can manage. A card you never needed is worth double the one that saved you. It is a real price, not a flourish. Claiming one Research Note costs BAT about 6 points of win rate and a second about 9 more; one Backdoor Routine costs AoS about 6. Carrying claims unspent rather than cashing them in is worth roughly 6 points to the finale against about 5 points off BAT and 5 off AoS. Playing all three games for the finale instead of for themselves moves the Pool from about 11 points of Target reduction to about 13, and the finale from 44.5% to 50.4%.

THE IMPOSTER SCENARIO

The Council has assembled a **Dossier** on you. Each card in it is an **Exhibit** — one thing they intend to ask about. You cannot refuse it and you cannot outrun it; you can only decide how much of it to face at a time, and you have nine sessions before the Council rules.

1. Deal 5 Knowledge, 5 Physical and 5 Cover-Up Scenarios at random from the 24-card Council Test library. Shuffle those 15 into a face-down **Dossier**.
2. An Exhibit's **Target** is its printed Target **minus 5**: a printed 8 is a Target of 3, a 9 is 4, a 10 is 5. Apart from the five Rewards below, nothing else printed on a Council Test is used in this scenario.
3. An Exhibit's **Damage** is **1**, or **2 if its Target is 5**.
4. The Imposter begins at **5 HP / 2 STR / 3 REC** with all 17 dice available.
5. Keep the Research Pool face-up beside the table. Play **9 sessions**.

> **YOU WIN BY CLEARING THE DOSSIER, AND YOU LOSE TWO WAYS**
>
> **Win** the moment the Dossier is empty and no Exhibit is left standing. **Lose** if the ninth session ends with any Exhibit still in the Dossier or on the table, or if your Health ever reaches 0. Either way you replay the finale, not the campaign.

The Council's attention

The Council examines one aspect of you at a time, and you can see what they will turn to next. The **attention** starts on Yellow and advances one step at the end of every session:

🟡 Yellow → 🟢 Green → 🔵 Blue → 🟣 Purple → 🔴 Red → back to Yellow.

You may only **apply** dice of the attention's colour **or the next colour on that list**. Other dice may still be committed and rolled — they simply cannot be applied, and they exhaust like any other committed die. Every colour is therefore usable for two consecutive sessions, which is what makes recovery a plan rather than a reflex: recover for the colour that is *coming*, not the one in front of you.

SESSION	1	2	3	4	**5**	6	7	8	9
ATTENTION	🟡	🟢	🔵	🟣	🔴	🟡	🟢	🔵	🟣

Session 5 is the hard one: Red and Yellow are the only colours you may apply, and you own exactly one Red die. Session 9 is the kindest, Purple and Red — so the Dossier should be nearly empty well before the Council's attention comes back around.

A session

1. **Deploy.** Take as many Exhibits as you like from the top of the Dossier — any number, including none — and place them face-up in front of you. For *each* one you deploy, **recover 1 exhausted die**, or mend 1 Health if nothing is exhausted.
2. **Answer the evidence.** Spend Research Pool cards on the Exhibits you just deployed (below). Exhibits deployed in an earlier session can no longer be answered.
3. **Strategy, twice.** Commit dice, roll, and apply hits to your standing Exhibits: a hit is 1 success, a Crit is 2, and only the allowed colours may be applied. Then take up any dice you have not applied, add more if you want, and throw again. Nothing is compulsory.
4. **Resolve.** Every Exhibit *still standing* deals its Damage to you. Then exhaust every committed die that applied nothing, and every die lying on an Exhibit that has just fallen. Recover up to **REC** exhausted dice, advance the attention, and tick the clock.

An Exhibit falls when the successes on it reach its Target. **Dice applied to an Exhibit that is still standing stay on it, and the successes they scored stay with them** — progress on an Exhibit is never lost, and those dice are neither available nor exhausted until the card falls.

What the Council lets slip

Five Council Tests print a **Reward**, and it still pays: read "if you succeed" as **when this Exhibit falls**, and take it during the Resolve step, after the dice on it have come back. The other three Reward cards modify a single attempt, which this scenario no longer has.

- **The Chamber Mechanism** — recover 2 exhausted dice.
- **The Sedative Ledger** — recover 3 exhausted dice.
- **The Vote** — recover *all* exhausted dice of one colour.
- **Tracks in the Yard** — recover 1 exhausted die of each of two colours.
- **The Narrow Stair** — the next Exhibit you deploy has its Target reduced by 1.

These are the only reason it matters *which* Exhibit you finish first. Four of the five are Target 3 as dealt, so the cheapest evidence is the evidence that pays.

Answering an Exhibit

A **retained** card answers only its own domain, and reduces the Target of one Exhibit you have just deployed. A card you spend is gone. Candidates answer nothing at all.

RETAINED CARD	ANSWERS	REDUCTION
BAT Research Note	Physical	−2 if you never spent it, −1 if you did
NAP Devious Opportunity	Knowledge	−2 if you never spent it, −1 if you did
AoS Backdoor Routine	Cover-Up	−2 if you never spent it, −1 if you did
Candidate	—	0

At most eight retained cards against fifteen Exhibits — 3 from BAT, 3 from NAP and 2 from AoS: the campaign answers a little over half the Dossier at best, and only while the right domains come up. No Exhibit drops below Target 1.

The decision the finale is built on

Deploying more than you must is how you get ahead of the clock, and each Exhibit pays you a die for it. Deploying more than you can *bury* is how you bleed. Count the Exhibits left against the sessions left and do not fall behind that number — slowing down when Health is short feels prudent and loses games, because the clock kills more reliably than the Council does.

Terminology: the **Research Pool** is the 18 carried-forward cards. The **Dossier** is the 15 Exhibits. The **dice pool** is the Imposter's dice. Card text that discards from the Research Pool never discards a die.

STANDALONE IMPOSTER MODE

You can play the finale without the campaign, and without opening another box: every card it needs is in this one. Take the 6 Research Notes, the 6 Devious Opportunities and the 6 Backdoor Routines. Draw at random **3 Notes, 3 Opportunities and 2 Routines** as retained — two from AoS because two is all a campaign could have claimed — and leave the rest as Candidates. Then for each retained card flip a coin: heads it was never spent and reduces by **2**, tails it was spent and reduces by **1**. Build the 15-card Dossier normally and play the nine-session finale.